Solution

Dimensional formula for

$$\frac{1}{2}mv^2 = [M][LT^{-1}]^2 = [ML^2T^{-2}]$$

Dimensional formula for

$$mgh = [M][LT^{-2}][L] = [ML^2T^{-2}]$$

$$[ML^2T^{-2}] = [ML^2T^{-2}]$$

Both sides are dimensionally the same, hence the equations $\frac{1}{2}mv^2 = mgh$ is dimensionally correct.

(iii) To establish the relation among various physical quantities

If the physical quantity Q depends upon the quantities Q_1, Q_2 and Q_3 ie. Q is proportional to Q_1, Q_2 and Q_3.

Then,

$$Q \propto Q_1^{\,a} Q_2^{\,b} Q_3^{\,c}$$

$$Q = k\, Q_1^{\,a} Q_2^{\,b} Q_3^{\,c}$$

where k is a dimensionless constant. When the dimensional formula of Q, Q_1, Q_2 and Q_3 are substituted, then according to the principle of homogeneity, the powers of M, L, T are made equal on both sides of the equation. From this, we get the values of a, b, c

EXAMPLE 1.15

Obtain an expression for the time period T of a simple pendulum. The time period T depends on (i) mass '*m*' of the bob (ii) length '*l*' of the pendulum and (iii) acceleration due to gravity *g* at the place where the pendulum is suspended. (Constant k = 2π) i.e

Solution

$$T \propto m^a l^b g^c$$

$$T = k.\quad m^a l^b g^c$$

Here k is the dimensionless constant. Rewriting the above equation with dimensions

$$[T^1] = [M^a]\,[L^b]\,[LT^{-2}]^c$$

$$[M^0L^0T^1] = [M^a\, L^{b+c}\, T^{-2c}]$$

Comparing the powers of M, L and T on both sides, a=0, b+c=0, -2c=1

Solving for a,b and c a = 0, b = 1/2, and c = −1/2

From the above equation T = k. m^0 $\ell^{1/2}\, g^{-1/2}$

$$T = k\left(\frac{\ell}{g}\right)^{1/2} = k\sqrt{\ell/g}$$

Experimentally k = 2π, hence $T = 2\pi\sqrt{\ell/g}$

Limitations of Dimensional analysis

1. This method gives no information about the dimensionless constants in the formula like 1, 2, ……..π, e (Euler number), etc.
2. This method cannot decide whether the given quantity is a vector or a scalar.
3. This method is not suitable to derive relations involving trigonometric, exponential and logarithmic functions.
4. It cannot be applied to an equation involving more than three physical quantities.
5. It can only check on whether a physical relation is dimensionally correct but not the correctness of the relation. For example using dimensional analysis, $s = ut + \frac{1}{3}at^2$ is dimensionally correct whereas the correct relation is $s = ut + \frac{1}{2}at^2$.

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